Interview Questions – Part B: Open-Ended Qualitative Questions (50 minutes)

Now, I would like to ask some questions to understand your experiences with buying and preparing food and using food assistance programs (such as SNAP or food stamps, food pantries, and school lunch programs) and how refugee organizations have helped you with food.

Questions on food and nutrition insecurity experiences and using food programs (40 minutes)

1. Tell me about your experience in buying and preparing food for your household in the U.S.
    a. Explore where they buy food and groceries, if they have cooking appliances, and if they know how to cook food.

I think I like to use the food stamps to buy the food. Food stamp is good, you know to buy something in money is very expensive. So, sometime I do not have enough money to go to smiths to buy something, maybe I go to pick up just milk. So its just all I have. Id love to buy food in food stamps because I do not have it for now so its very hard for me.

FQ: where do you go to buy the food?

Smiths, I go to Costco to buy food, Walmart to buy food. Sometimes smiths.

FQ: do you have things that you can cook food with? Like a pot and a pan.

Before I stay I have them to cook the food good, now I don't have. Any. You see that one over there (points to a big pot) Its my cousin give it to me that one. Its so big. It's the only thing I have right now.

FQ: Do you know how to cook food?

Yeah I know how to cook

FQ: do you usually cook food that you learned how to make at home?

Yeah. My mom learning me how to cook the food. Sometimes when I cook to much I have asthma and I am not able to cook everything.

FQ: Do have an inhaler for your asthma?

They give me before, the person who is stealing my green card with my social. I put all the things for my asthma inside the bag and they took from me. So right now I don't have anything.

2. Review answers in the Food Insecurity sections and ask the following questions if they have experienced food insecurity in the last 12 months; if not, go to question #3:
    a. You indicated that you often/sometimes had problems with food in the last 12 months, can you tell me more about that?

Yeah, so I have it hard to find because the apartment I stay in. I stay before with my boyfriend. The landlord they came and yell, because me and my boyfriend no have enough income to afford apartment. My boyfriend give them pay stub to hold apartment for me. My boyfriend not living with me. After that the landlord talk to DWS say my boyfriend live with me. After that they not give me the food stamp again, they close my case.

Even the childcare, Im not have any. Even the food stamp, I still not have any the food stamps. For the past one year today, Im not have any benefit. The benefit I have just only Medicaid. Just all, solike food stamp or cost stamp or something I cant have any. It just happen, that's why different people they help me. Because now I am not working. I don't have working paper.

FQ: can I ask why you are unemployed?

I can get a job because I don't have the real document. I have copy one, because the real one I don't have. That's the problem, I don't have the job.

FQ: When do you think you will be able to get a job?

Im think too much,how I am going to get the job. I have the police record to get a job, its very hard for me to find it. So right now I need help to find a job, its very hard.

FQ: do you think there are any language barriers?

Yeah. I want to communicate with someone to help me find a job because my situation is too much right now. So when I find the job, its going to help a little.

i. Explore the nature of the problem such as unemployment, low income, language barriers, and lack of knowledge about resources.

b. Can you explain what you did to find help with food and if that worked?

Because you know, something from my country, when you are homeless or you don't have any food with your kids. You don't have anything. Sometimes friend or family they helping to protect your kids.

c. Can you explain how your <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> helped you with food?
   i. Explore training on budget management, preparing meals, purchasing foods, using food pantries and farmers markets, and applying for food programs such as SNAP.
   ii. What has been most useful to you among things that your <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> do?

CCS.

The catholic because they bring us here. Like refugee. So something happen you go to them. Sometimes they going to help but like my green card I lost, I go to apply. And sometimes they helping me fill my documents because I don't have car to drive all the way over there. They don't come here to help me.

The catholic done for me, sometime,right now no they are not being helpful.

iii. Ask those who are still receiving <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> support: Do you feel comfortable finding help with food without the help of <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> when you graduate from <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY>?
iv. Is there anything that you wish you had learned or could learn from caseworkers of <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> to help you with food?

Yeah. I think right now before I have caseworker to them. The caseworker in 2015. I have a caseworker over there because the caseworker is no longer working over there so right now I have no caseworker to fight about for my kids.

d. Ask those who graduated from <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> to determine when food became a problem: Can you tell me when food became a problem?
e. Review answers in the Utilization section and ask the following questions if they have used SNAP/WIC/NSLP/Food Pantries/Other programs in the last 12 months; if not go to #f below:
    i. You indicated that you have used XXX program, can you tell me how you heard about this program and how you applied for it?
    ii. Can you explain your experience with using this program? Explore how often they use the program and how they feel about it.
    iii. Tell me about the food you received from them.
    iv. What % of your foods come from this program?

    Repeat i-iv for other programs they have used.

School lunch program,

i. You indicated that you have used XXX program, can you tell me how you heard about this program and how you applied for it?

Some nurse. Nurse they coming to my house about my son, that's why they talk to me about.

FQ: The nurse came for your son?

Yeah the nurse they coming to my house to help me. Like his physical. They come very week.

FQ: does he have any health problems?

He has a leg problem and headaches. He has a surgery in head. He is bow legged.He has something in head, they take it out.

FQ: The nurse is how you learned about the school lunch program?

Yeah

FQ: you have two kids under the school lunch program?

i. Can you explain your experience with using this program? Explore how often they use the program and how they feel about it.

The lunch program, I think. Because they going to school. They get free food at school.

FQ: do you feel comfortable knowing they go to school and get the food that they need?

Yeah. I think the program I am worrying about it is. One day gabriela (her daughter) she go to school. I think She eat the breakfast in the morning. Shes vomiting to much in school. makes me worried for her.

FQ: what do you worry about her health when she eats the food?

I worry that the food is not good for her. That's why shes so vomiting in school. Maybe I worry, she get a cold. I am not worried about the food at school, I worry about Gabriela get cold.

FQ: how often do they use?

I think she say she get to school, they eat at school everyday, they eat breakfast in morning and lunch.

FQ: do you know what kind of food they receive from the program?

No

i. What % of your foods come from this program?

What I remember they eat in the morning and the afternoon they eat. Every week they bring some canned food back. She bring home. She get the thing in little cup, like pineapple, fruit, and apple sauce.

FQ: do they give canned food?

They give different things, everytime its different.

Food pantry.

How did you hear about it?

My friend she have that one before. That's why she told me about. Someone told me

FQ: did you have to apply for it?

I don't understand

FQ: Did you have to fill out a paper for them or could you just use the food pantry?

I just go use the food pantry

FQ: so you can just go you don't have to talk to anyone?

No I think they do the application online, that's how they give it to me. Sometimes they bring the food to me. Because I do not have a car, so yeah. The application I do it, they deliver the food to my house.

FQ: how did you apply?

I think the nurse coming to my house she help me. She help me do it on my phone.

FQ: can you explain your experience with using this program?

I don't have good experience, because I don't understand how to do it. When I read English, I do not know. Cause me no read English. So some people help me how to apply something, how to know my email. So its just.

FQ: how far away is the food pantry?

Sometimes, it takes one month or two month for them to deliver it to me.

FQ: do you ever go get the food?

No, only the place where I receive the diapers, the wipes, that's the place go to.

FQ: can you tell me what kind of food you receive from them?

Sometimes, I receive good food, some meat, beef. Sometimes I receive chicken, I receive corn, I receive salad. I get some rice, Because flour I cant get it. Sometimes they bring potato fries, frozen. Then we can make them for the kids. Sometimes they deliver good food sometimes they deliver not good food. (so not all the food you can eat?) Sometimes I cant eat it.

FQ: how much of the food you have do you get from deliveries?

20%

FQ: So you get food from delivers, the store, and sometimes your sister?

Yes, sometimes they don't deliver the food.

FQ: what kind of things did they deliver that you were not gonna eat?

Pork, I don't eat pork. Some beans, I don't like those ones. Some white beans I like. I don't know how to say it in English. Some beans, I don't like it. Sometimes American food, I don't like it.

FQ: you don't eat because you don't like it, or you are scared its going to hurt your stomach?

No its not like that, because sometimes me like it Im going to eat it. Because sometimes me no like it I am not going to touch that one. Because not all food I like.

3. Tell me about your experience in finding and buying foods from your culture.
    a. How important eating foods from your culture is to you?
    Like my country is like kasfa food, its like kasfa food. Its very hard to like and like some they call ganggang.
    FQ: can you find those here?
    Sometimes its really hard for me to find it, to eat it. In sometimes African store, that's where my sister go to buy it and bring to me to eat it. It not like American food (so. Its hard for you to find them?) its very hard.
    I eat like chicken, like fruit food, then like chips, and like cookie.
    FQ: do you like American food?
    Yeah I like American food, because the problem I like American food. My kids they love American food, sometimes I cook my country food they don't understand how to eat it. And they love American food. Its American food me make everyday for them. I love to eat with them, sometimes I make rice and chicken to eat it. Sometimes they love noodles. This one they love porridge.
    b. Where do you get your vegetables and cultural foods from?

c. How does/did <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> help you with finding foods from your culture?

No they not helping.

i. What did they do that was the most helpful and why?

d. Do you use Farmers Market to buy foods from your culture?

Yeah, I go over sometimes. Sometimes I go to Walmart to find it, sometimes they bring in African store, or Chinese store to find it. Sometimes Chinese store has a lot of food from my country.

e. Have you used the Sunnyvale Farmers Market (4013 S 700 W)?

Not yet, Im not using that one before. I like to use it but the problem is car.

i. if yes, how did you hear about it and what has been your experience with that?

Suggestions for future strategies to improve food access (10 minutes)

READ TO PARTICIPANT: This is the last section of our interview and I would like to ask your suggestions on how to improve food security among refugees.

1. What do you think keeps people from your community from using food assistance programs that are available to them?

   Because some people they need to, some people they don't need to. Like me,I need, and like my friend she no need. All this things I need right now, because me no have job, me no have work, me nohave food stamp, so that's why I am using it.

   Some people I don't understand how they need it, how they don't need it, some people they different.
2. How do you think we can ensure that refugees can access food assistance programs when they need help with food?

   Because you know, this country is not my country. All this things I am asking for me to help with my kids. Me have four kids, and I don't have anyone to help me. So I go to the place with the refugee people. Me help my kids.
3. What do you think <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> and other refugee organizations can do to ensure refugees have enough food?

   Yeah, the catholic they bring us before, they give us case worker. They helping food, they helping clothes. They helping a lot of things. Like now in Arizona, I hear about that on they helping, but after me move here they give me caseworker, but this past year they don't help me with anything. My caseworker gone I still have caseworker I spent a long time me no go to them.
4. Do you want to share anything else regarding your experiences with food insecurity and using food assistance programs since you moved to the U.S. and since you graduated from <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY>?

   No